committee of its own.) She is alleged to have ignored verbal complaints routed through the unit manager. According to one of the FIRs filed by an employee, Ashwini dismissed her complaint against Raza, saying, "Why do you want to highlight this? Let it go."

With many of the affected employees coming from financially weak backgrounds, they apparently had no option but to endure the ordeal. Fear of social stigma and family disapproval further drove them into silence. Speaking about one's harassment, Mumbai-based psychiatrist Dr Harish Shetty points out, is rarely a simple choice. "What we see is a combination of helplessness and fear—fear that no one will believe them, fear of losing their job and fear of social consequences. I have patients come and tell me, 'If this comes out, my family will worry about my future, who will marry me?' That sense of shame and social stigma can be very powerful in India."

ALTERNATIVE NARRATIVES

What is equally surprising is that no one outside noticed anything amiss at the BPO. Employees of other firms would see TCS staff hang out in groups, sitting at long tables in the dining hall on the terrace. "There would be groups of men and young women, but they seemed friendly with each other. Nothing indicated such things could be going on," says a woman who works in the same building.

Meanwhile, the families of the accused as well as the defence lawyers deny the charges. Riyaz Memon, Raza's uncle, questions why only Muslim men were arrested and not other seniors from the Nashik office. "They are being unnecessarily targeted," he alleges. Advocate Baba Sayyad, defence lawyer for five of the accused, including Raza and Tausif, says the case has been heavily politicised, describing it as "a love story gone sour". Asked about claims that the accused had links to a preacher in Malaysia—an allegation under police investigation—he says: "No such allegations have been made in the FIR. The media is going by hearsay... There is no evidence or basis for this." The FIR and remand report, he says, were likewise silent on allegations of forced conversions; according to him, the accused merely engaged in "friendly discussions" on religion and did not denigrate any faith. However, police sources confirm that allegations of religious harassment have been made in some of these FIRs.



MAYUR BARGAJE

GROUND ZERO The building that houses the TCS office in Nashik



"It is a case of a love story gone sour... has been heavily politicised. No allegations [of links to a preacher in Malaysia] have been made in the FIR. There is no evidence or basis for this"

BABA SAYYAD, *Defence lawyer for five of the accused*

Others suspect a political angle to the whole controversy, saying it is meant to deflect attention away from recent controversies, such as the felling of trees for the Kumbh Mela in Nashik, and the alleged exploitation of women by the self-styled godman Ashok Kharat. These sources also dismissed media reports that the police posed as housekeeping staff to gather evidence, pointing out that TCS hired such staff through agencies and also had an access control mechanism that regulated entry.

A harsher line is that TCS was caught napping in the whole episode. In defence, TCS CEO and MD K. Krithivasan in a statement said, "A preliminary review of the systems and records pertaining to the Nashik unit indicates we have not received any complaints of the nature being alleged on our ethics or POSH channels. We remain fully committed to the safety, dignity and well-being of every employee." He also dismissed media reports about the Nashik unit being shut down, calling them "absolutely untrue". The company, he said, is "focused on supporting our employees and ensuring a safe and respectful workplace across all our locations" and continues to "extend full cooperation to the law enforcement agencies so that the matter is investigated thoroughly, transparently and brought to a rightful conclusion". Expect these competing narratives to be put to test as the probe gathers pace. ■

—with Dhaval S. Kulkarni and Sonali Acharjee